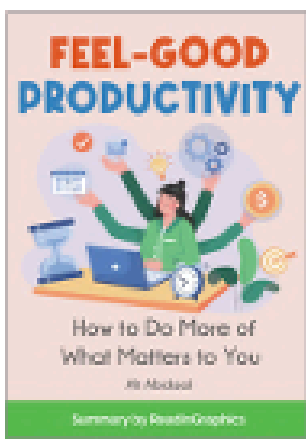




FEEL-GOOD PRODUCTIVITY

How to Do More of What Matters to You

Ali Abdaal



The Big “So What”

Feel-Good Productivity is a fresh approach to productivity. It seeks to achieve more not by pushing harder, but by feeling better. In this book, Ali Abdaal shares how to harness positive emotions to boost your energy, find fulfillment, and achieve more of what matters in a sustainable way.



What is Feel-Good Productivity?



Abdaal initially relied on hard work and discipline to complete medical school. However, as a doctor, he found traditional productivity methods to be unsustainable. He started to question conventional productivity, research alternatives, and eventually developed *Feel-Good Productivity*—an approach that focuses on feeling good to achieve more, rather than relying on constant discipline and hustling.

- This shift helped Abdaal to feel more positive and productive at work, and refocus on what truly mattered. Eventually, he left medicine and became an author and YouTuber.



Why *Feel-Good Productivity* Works



The Broaden-and-Build Theory by psychologist Barbara Fredrickson explains why feeling good can help us become more productive, resilient, and effective at problem-solving. Positive emotions can:

- Broaden our awareness, allowing us to see more possibilities and solutions; and

KEY QUOTES

“Success doesn’t lead to feeling good. Feeling good leads to success.”

“Positive emotions are the fuel that drives the engine of human flourishing.”

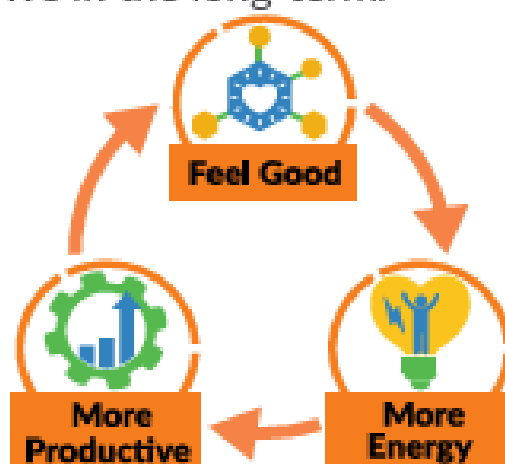
“By understanding and applying what makes you feel good, you won’t just transform your work. You’ll transform your life.”

- Build mental and emotional resources over time, giving us the resilience and social bonds to thrive in the long-term.



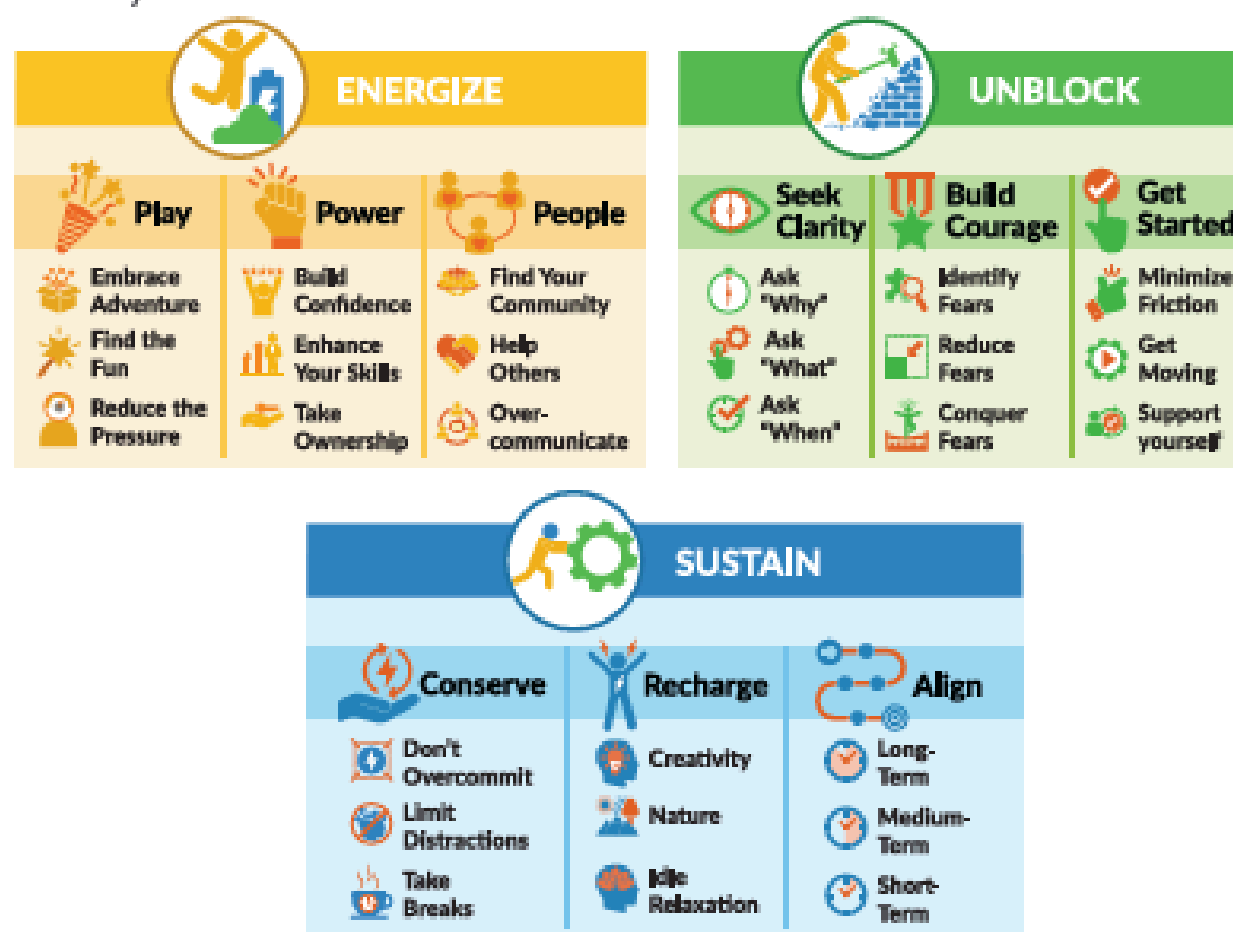
Feel-good productivity works for 3 main reasons:

- Positive emotions release feel-good hormones (endorphins, serotonin, dopamine oxytocin) that boost our energy and motivation.
- Positive emotions also reduce stress by mitigating stress responses and restoring calm after stressful experiences. This enhances resilience and well-being.
- Research shows that happiness doesn't come from success, but the reverse. People who nurture positive emotions exhibit higher creativity, productivity, and fulfillment. They're more likely to excel, build strong relationships, and achieve long-term success.



Feel-Good Productivity aims not just to do more, but to achieve what matters most, balancing productivity with a fulfilling life. This book serves as a guide and toolkit to help you apply the philosophy to your life.

- It is structured in 3 parts, each containing science-backed strategies and experiments or practices that you can test out in your life.



KEY QUOTES

"What's contained in these pages isn't just another productivity system to help you get more done at any cost. It's about doing more of what matters to you. It'll help you learn more about yourself, what you love and what really motivates you."

"This book isn't a to-do list. It's a philosophy—a way of creating your own personalised productivity toolkit."



Part 1: Energize

To use positive emotions to energize yourself, integrate 3 “energizers” into your daily life: Play, Power and People.



Play



Play isn't just for kids; it's also a powerful tool for adults to recharge and gain new ideas. A playful mindset relieves stress, provides fresh perspectives, and reconnects us with our curiosity.

- For example, Richard Feynman was facing burnout after years of intense work. One day, he became curious about some wobbling plates—this playful approach reignited his passion for physics, eventually leading to discoveries that won him a Nobel Prize.
- You can incorporate play in 3 ways: (i) embracing adventure, (ii) finding fun in your tasks, and (iii) reducing pressure.



Embracing adventure: See life as a game, full of surprises and opportunities to be discovered.

- Choose your character: Just like role-playing games, you can adopt a playful alter-ego in real-life. Here are 8 “play personalities” identified by Dr. Stuart Brown:
 - *Collectors* find joy in gathering items or organizing activities like a garage sale.
 - *Competitors* enjoy challenging themselves and winning, be it sports, games, or friendly contests.
 - *Explorers* seek out new experiences, from travel to new ideas/perspectives.
 - *Creators* love to make things (e.g. inventions, art, music).
 - *Storytellers* are drawn to narratives and imagination-based activities, e.g. writing or acting.

KEY QUOTES

“Seriousness is overrated. If you want to achieve more without ruining your life, the first step is to approach your work with a sense of play.”

“Life is stressful. Play makes it fun.”

“Remembering what play is all about and making it part of our daily lives are probably the most important factors in being a fulfilled human being.”
—Stuart Brown

- *Jokers* enjoy humor, often making light of situations to bring joy and laughter to others.
- *Directors* love to coordinate people, ideas, or activities.
- *Kinesthetes* delight in physical, movement-focus activities, such as sports and dance.



- Get curious: Research shows that curiosity enhances dopamine release, improving memory and engagement. Ask questions and learn for the joy of learning, not only for maximizing results.



Look for the fun in any task: Any task—even routine ones—can be made fun and enjoyable.

- Remind yourself to have fun. Try placing Post-It notes in strategic locations to prompt yourself: “How can this be more fun?” Make mundane tasks enjoyable, like adding music to your work or study sessions.
- Don’t fixate on the outcome; learn to enjoy the process.
 - Renowned psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi found that people are more likely to enjoy a task and get in “flow” when they immerse fully in the task.
 - Transform mundane tasks into a *personal game*. For example, when storyteller Matthew Dicks worked at McDonald’s, he tried creative ways to pitch BBQ sauce to customers, turning an otherwise repetitive job into a fun game.



Reduce the pressure: It’s hard to be creative or productive when you’re stressed and uptight.

KEY QUOTES

“When you step into the right ‘play personality’, every day abounds with opportunities to see life as a game, filled with surprises and side quests.”

“Being curious about everything not only makes you more creative. It enriches your life.”
—Walter Isaacson

“Remember Mary Poppins: there’s an element of fun in every task, even if it isn’t always obvious.”

“With a little creative thinking, you can find joy in any process, however mundane it might seem.”

- Reframe mistakes as “data points” for learning. In an experiment, students became less willing to try when they were penalized for failures. This shows why we should reduce the stakes of failure.
- Be sincere, not serious: For example, instead of trying to give a perfect presentation, focus on sharing your message more authentically. This can make your interactions less stressful, more natural and rewarding.



Power



Power here means personal empowerment, not controlling others. It's about taking charge of the decisions, actions, and habits that shape your future.

- You can empower yourself by (i) building confidence, (ii) improving skills, and (iii) taking ownership.



Build your confidence: Your beliefs about your abilities affect both your performance and enjoyment. In one study, participants who believed they were fitter performed better and enjoyed workouts more, even though their fitness levels were actually similar to other participants. To build confidence:

- Prime yourself for success by imagining a more confident version of yourself. When you feel unsure, ask: “What would it look like if I were truly confident?” Visualize yourself handling the task confidently and successfully, and use affirmations like “I can do this” or “Almost there.”
- Vicarious mastery: Observe others who have succeeded in similar challenges. If you're learning rock-climbing, study successful climbers. If you're starting a business, immerse yourself in successful entrepreneurial stories. This provides social proof—if others can do it, so can you.



Enhance your skills through “enactive mastery”, i.e. learn by doing.

- Adopt a beginner's mind (Shoshin approach): Approach tasks with humility and curiosity. Ask yourself, “How would I do this if I were new to it?” Set aside preconceptions, open yourself to new methods, and remove the fear of failure.

KEY QUOTES

“Failures are only failures when you think they are – and not every problem need be approached with such a straight face.”

“No failure is ever just a failure. It's an invitation to try something new.”

“‘Power’ is a scary word, but it doesn't have to be... we simply mean feeling empowered to take your job, life and future into your own hands.”

“Confidence isn't something you're born with; it's something you learn.”

“Believing you can is the first step to making sure you actually can.”

“If they can, you can too.”

“Beginners don't hold strong beliefs about what will work, they just try.”

*“He who teaches learns.”
—Seneca*

- Teach as you learn (Protégé Effect): Teaching others reinforces your learning better than passive study. Ask yourself: “How can I teach others even if I’m not an expert yet?” Guide or mentor those who’re a few steps behind you to solidify your learning.



Take ownership of your life. According to the self-determination theory, the more ownership or autonomy you feel, the more engaged and fulfilled you’ll be. Even if you can’t control the situation, you can control your approach and mindset.

- Take charge of your processes: Even if you can’t choose what to do, you can choose how to do it. For instance, a teacher may not choose the curriculum, but they can control how they teach. Approach the task in a way that makes it more enjoyable, engaging, and meaningful.
- Choose a positive, autonomous mindset. In any situation, you can always choose your attitude.
 - Stop thinking “I have to...” or “Why must I....” as they only amplify negative feelings about the task/situation.
 - Instead, use the words “I choose to...” or “I get to...” This transforms perceived obligations into conscious choices, reinforcing the sense of control over your mindset and response.



People



Our interactions generate relational energy that affects our motivation and performance. People who emit positive energy uplift us, while “energy vampires” drain us.

- To harness positive relational energy: (i) find your community, (ii) help others, and (iii) over-communicate.



Find Your Community: Surround yourself with people who inspire you and align with your goals and interests. A like-minded community boosts motivation, creativity, and a sense of belonging.

- Adopt a collaborative mindset: See your peers as allies, not rivals. Teamwork isn’t just about splitting the work—it’s also about mutual support, growth, and being part of a shared journey.

KEY QUOTES

*“You don’t need to be a guru.
You can just be a guide.”*

*“If you can’t choose what you
work on, you can still choose
how you work on it. The
outcome isn’t always in your
hands. But the process, and
certainly your mindset, often
is.”*

*“There’s an extraordinary
power to be gained by doing
it your way. Even in the
most disempowering
circumstances.”*

*“Everything can be taken
from a man but one thing:
the last of the human
freedoms—to choose one’s
attitude in any given set of
circumstances, to choose
one’s own way.”
—Viktor Frankl*

*“There are some people who
naturally uplift our energy –
the trick is finding them.”*

*“Teamwork is as much a
psychological state as a way
of dividing up tasks.”*

- Create synchronicity through coordinated activities or shared rhythms. This creates unity and support, and improves both mood and energy levels. Even if you're not working on the same task, you can work in sync, such as working on your own tasks in parallel.



Help others: When we help others, it triggers the release of oxytocin that creates a “helper’s high”. It also energizes both parties, and strengthens connections.

- Perform random acts of kindness: Small acts (like a kind word or getting someone a drink) can brighten someone’s day, foster goodwill, and boost your own mood.
- Ask for help: Often, we hesitate to ask for help as we worry that we’ll impose on others. Yet, research shows that seeking assistance can strengthen bonds and make others feel good. This is called the “Benjamin Franklin Effect,” named after how Franklin turned a rival into an ally by asking for a small favor.
 - Start by assuming that people want to help. Make requests in person where possible, as it’s more effective than virtual requests. Use positive language (e.g. “I admire your work and would really love your opinion on this.”) Don’t apologize for the request or make it quid-pro-quo.



Overcommunicate. As a rule of thumb, go beyond what you think is the minimum level of communication.

- Overcommunicate the positives to deepen bonds and amplify collective energy. Capitalize on good news by:
 - (i) Sharing them enthusiastically to uplift others; and
 - (ii) Celebrating others’ achievements: Show genuine delight, e.g. “I feel so happy for you!” Acknowledge their effort and express optimism for their future.
- Overcommunicate the negatives: Be transparent about setbacks or challenges to prevent misunderstandings and to build trust. It’s better to be direct and constructive than to sugarcoat or lie.
 - (i) Describe what happened in observable, non-judgmental terms, e.g. “We were a week late in project completion” (not “You were irresponsible for missing the deadline.”)

KEY QUOTES

“When we work in synchrony with other people, we tend to be more productive. Synchronicity makes us want to help others. And it makes us want to help ourselves.”

“By stopping what you’re doing and offering help to people at random, you can boost your endorphin levels and help yourself work harder.”

“When framed correctly, asking for help makes the person you’re asking feel as good as the help makes you feel.”

“Not only do we too rarely help others, we also too rarely ask for help.”

“When you think you’ve communicated plenty, you almost certainly haven’t.”

“Overcommunication won’t just inspire them. It will inspire you too.”

“When you think you’ve communicated too much, you probably haven’t communicated enough.”

- (ii) Focus on concrete outcomes, not blame, e.g. "The client lodged a complaint and almost cancelled the contract."
- (iii) Provide constructive alternatives, e.g. "Next time..."



Part 2: Unblock

Procrastination stems not from a lack of motivation or discipline, but from Uncertainty, Fear, and Inertia. These feelings cause us to delay decisions or action, which makes us feel worse and procrastinate even more in a vicious cycle.



Seek Clarity (Overcome Uncertainty)



Often, we don't take action because we're unsure of what to do. We're afraid to make the wrong decision, so we keep delaying.

- Gain clarity by asking: why, what, and when. Knowing your purpose, goals, and tasks improves focus and motivation.



Ask "why" to clarify your core purpose.

- Define your purpose for a task/project. Ask "What's the purpose for this?" and craft a statement of purpose to guide your actions. For example, are you exercising to attain 6-pack abs, or to have a healthier and more balanced lifestyle?
- Ask why 5x to peel back layers of surface motivations and find your real purpose. For example, "Why am I doing this project?" Because it's work. → "Why do I work?" To earn money. → "Why do I earn money?" etc.



Ask "What?" to shift from vague, outcome-based goals to specific, input-based goals.

- Set NICE goals. Set immediate, achievable goals that are:
 - Near-term (daily or weekly);
 - Input-based (things you can do immediately);
 - Controllable; and
 - Energizing.

KEY QUOTES

"To tell the chronic procrastinator to just do it would be like saying to a clinically depressed person, cheer up."
—Joseph Ferrari

"All too often, we approach procrastination by treating the symptoms rather than the underlying causes. And all too often, those causes relate to our mood: when we feel bad, we achieve less."

"Asking 'why' repeatedly reminds us of what we should really be focusing on—and allows us to home in on it."

"You might know what your ultimate 'why' is; but without a clear end-goal, you'll struggle to work out how to get there."

Unlike SMART goals which focus on outcomes (e.g. "Write a novel in 12 months"), NICE goals focus on the journey (e.g. "Write for 20 minutes daily").

- Do a pre-mortem: Envision what could go wrong with your project (e.g. missed deadlines, technical issues) and brainstorm solutions to address such issues upfront.



Ask "when" to clarify when to act and how to create positive habits.

- Use implementation intentions (or habit stacking) to pair a specific action with an existing routine, e.g. "After breakfast, I'll review my goals." This creates a mental association between the new task and a daily habit, making it easier to build new habits.
- Use time blocking to allocate specific time slots for specific tasks, so you take charge of your time and energy instead of reacting to external demands. Block your time at 3 levels, then adapt as you go along.
 - (i) Commit time for *specific tasks* that you've been avoiding.
 - (ii) Organize the bulk of your *day* into time blocks, e.g. assign time in the mornings for focused work and afternoons for administrative tasks.
 - (iii) Plan out your entire *week* to ensure that you've set aside time for your key priorities such as work, family, exercise, personal growth, hobbies, and relaxation.



Build Courage (Overcome Fear)



Fear is triggered in the brain's amygdala when it perceives a threat. Such perceived threats—such as the fear of rejection or fear of failure—are seldom dangerous, but they make us so anxious that we can't think clearly or take productive action.

- The key is to move forward despite fear—to face it with courage rather than avoid it. You can do so by (i) identifying your fear, (ii) diminishing it, and (iii) rising above it.



Identify your fears: Once you understand the specific fears holding you back, it's possible to tackle them constructively.

KEY QUOTES

"Forget SMART goals. What you need are goals that feel NICE (near-term, input-based, controllable and energising)."

"If you don't know when you're doing something, chances are you won't do it."

"Structure gives you more freedom, not less...you're designing your life according to your priorities."

"Time blocking isn't about creating a rigid schedule that stresses you out; it's about providing structure and ensuring there's dedicated time for what matters most to you."

"It isn't lack of talent or inspiration that's holding you back. It's fear."

"Find courage. To look at our fear, acknowledge it, and move past it."

For example, Abdaal procrastinated for 7 years to start his Youtube channel—once he realized he was delaying due to a fear of failure, he managed to push through the fear.

- Name your fears to reduce their intensity and build the self-awareness needed to move past them. In a study on phobias, participants who labeled their fear felt calmer and better equipped to face the object of their phobia. By contrast, the more you avoid something, the scarier it seems.
 - Ask yourself: What am I afraid of? Where is this fear coming from? Is it based on fact or perception? Are you doubting your abilities or worrying about others' opinions? Understand the fear to move past it.
- Shift your self-identity: We hold ourselves back with labels like "I'm not a good presenter" or "I'm just not adventurous." To encourage new behaviors, change limiting labels (e.g. "I'm a perfectionist") to empowering ones (e.g. "I'm a learner").



Diminish your fears: Often, we amplify a fear by imagining worst-case scenarios that are unlikely to materialize. You can do the reverse—put the fear in perspective to reduce its intensity.

- Use the 10/10/10 Rule: Consider how much the feared outcome will matter in 10 minutes, 10 weeks, or 10 years. For example, you might realize that being rejected for a job doesn't really matter in the long term.
- Start taking baby steps to build confidence; don't wait to feel confident before you start. Ask yourself: Can I start even if I'm not confident? Most of the time, it's ok to start with small, imperfect steps, then slowly improve over time.



Conquer your fears: It's impossible to eliminate all fears. However, we can rise above the fears and push forward in spite of them.

- Reduce self-focus: The "spotlight effect" happens when we overestimate how much others are focusing on us. The next time you fret over what others think about you, remember that people are too focused on themselves to notice if you made a bad joke or if you're wearing mismatched socks. Even if they notice, no one really cares.
- Adopt an alter ego: In a study, children who imagined themselves as superheroes became more focused,

KEY QUOTES

"The solution isn't to get rid of fear...it's to develop the courage to face up to it."

"Knowledge is power. Getting to know our fears is the first step towards overcoming them."

"Labels are...tools that help us make sense of who we are. If we can change our labels, we can often change our behaviour."

"The failures we're worried about now aren't the ones that will always define us. And that the fears we have now won't always carry such significance."

"Make a start. You won't need to get perfect for a long time yet."

"We can't eradicate all our fears. We need to overcome them. That means finding a way to move from fear to courage."

"The truth is, everyone is concerned mostly about themselves...They're not spending much time (if any) thinking about us."

self-controlled, and resilient. This is called the “*Batman Effect*”. Leverage this effect by visualizing yourself as someone who’s confident and fearless.

- Examples: When Adele was still an inexperienced singer, she overcame her fear of public appearances by creating an alter ego—a blend of Sasha Fierce and June Carter. Ali Abdaal puts on fake glasses and steps into the identity of Charles Xavier whenever he needs to speak publicly.
- What alter ego can you adopt to diminish your personal inhibitions and embody the traits you admire? Before a difficult task, visualize yourself becoming this alternate-you. Reinforce it with affirmations like “I am fearless” or “I am unstoppable.”



Get Started (Overcome Inertia)



Inertia is another major cause of procrastination. Newton's First Law states that an object at rest stays at rest, and an object in motion stays in motion unless acted on by another force (e.g. friction).

- In other words, it takes a lot more energy to get started than to stay in motion. It’s like riding a bike—it’s hard to ride uphill, but once you reach the top the momentum carries you downhill effortlessly. You can overcome inertia in 3 ways: (i) minimize friction, (ii) get moving, and (iii) support yourself.



Minimize friction or the effort required to start a task:

- Modify your surroundings to make it easier get started on a task. Remove obstacles that add resistance, and make the desired action the default. For example, place your ukulele visibly in the living room to remind yourself to practice, or turn off phone notifications to reduce phone usage.
- Use the Five-Minute Rule: When you don't feel like doing something, overcome emotional resistance by committing to work on the task for just 5 minutes. At the end of 5 minutes, you can choose to stop or continue. Often you'll keep going, but even if you stop, you'd have done 5 minutes of work.

KEY QUOTES

“When we embody the traits of a fearless, confident alterego, we can tap into a reservoir of courage and determination that we might not feel our regular selves possess.”

“As Newton recognised, it takes way more energy to get started than it does to keep going.”

“When you’re doing nothing, it’s easy to carry on doing nothing. And when you’re working, it’s much easier to carry on working.”

“Even when we know we really should do something, we often find ourselves in places that make it needlessly difficult to get started.”

“The best antidote to doing nothing is simply to do something.”



Get moving: Focus on concrete, immediate action steps to develop a bias to action. These are more likely to spur you into action compared to overthinking a long-term goal.

- Define your next action step: Identify the smallest next step, then act on it. For example, to get started on writing, the smallest action step could be to open a new document on your computer or take out your writing pad.
- Track your progress daily using a journal, app, or calendar. Surround yourself with visual reminders of how far you have come and what else you need to do. This motivates you to keep going with consistent effort.



Support yourself: Create personal and social support systems to make it easier to stay motivated and to persevere in the long run.

- Partner with an accountability buddy and schedule regular check-ins. This generates relational energy and motivation to follow through. Ideally, find someone who shares your goals, then agree in advance on the ground rules and processes (e.g. check-in times).
- Practice self-compassion: If you miss a commitment, don't dwell on it—this only makes you feel bad and procrastinate more. Instead, forgive yourself and focus on the small wins, e.g. “I didn't do X, but I managed to do Y.”



Part 3: Sustain

Even if we energize ourselves and overcome procrastination, burnout can still set in when we take on too much, fail to rest/recover, or invest in goals that are misaligned with our true selves. To sustain productivity, we need to Conserve, Recharge, and Align.



Conserve



Overexertion burnout occurs when we try to do too much too quickly. Think of it like sprinting throughout a marathon, which is unsustainable.

KEY QUOTES

“We need clear, concrete steps to take, rather than distant, abstract goals. Otherwise we might do nothing at all.”

“Tracking your progress provides you with tangible evidence that you're moving towards your goals.”

“People boost our feel-good emotions and make us want to get started. Life is better with friends around.”

“You can focus on the small losses. Or you can celebrate the small wins.”

“Procrastination isn't something we can always control. Forgiving ourselves is something we can.”

“Burnout isn't just a thing that happens to overworked people in stressful jobs. It can happen to anyone when work stops feeling meaningful, enjoyable or manageable.”

- Similar to how a car needs fuel and maintenance, we need energy and focus to function effectively over time. Conserve your energy by (i) avoiding overcommitment, (ii) limiting distractions, and (iii) taking regular breaks.



Don't overcommit. Protect your mental and physical resources by setting boundaries around work and rest.

- Create an energy budget: Allocate energy to high-priority tasks, like how you'd allocate financial resources to investments. Get clear on your key goals and filter out unnecessary commitments.
 - Create 2 lists: (i) long-term goals and dreams, and (ii) active projects you're working on right now.
 - Decide on the total time to invest in active projects each week (ideally limit to <10 hours), then allocate the time to maximize returns.
- Learn to say "No" to requests that don't align with your priorities.
 - (i) Use Derek Sivers' advice: Only say "yes" to things that you feel enthusiastic about ("hell yeah!"). Say "no" to everything else.
 - (ii) Consider the opportunity costs: saying "yes" to one thing means saying "no" to something else.
 - (iii) If a request happens only in a few weeks' time, ask yourself: "Would I be excited if this was happening tomorrow?" This stops you from accepting commitments just because your calendar is currently clear.



Limit distractions so they won't drain your energy and focus. Multitasking involves "switching costs", since we need mental energy to toggle between tasks. For optimum productivity, focus on one task at a time, but switch tasks periodically to avoid mental exhaustion.

- Add friction: Make distractions less accessible or enticing, such as keeping distracting apps in a sub-folder on your phone, or even locking your phone in a drawer. You're less likely to engage in a distraction if you must make a deliberate effort to reach it.

KEY QUOTES

"If you can make yourself feel better, you won't just achieve more—you'll last longer, too."

"Overcommitting is simply too easy. But that doesn't mean it can't be resisted."

"We tend to think we can do everything. It's a myth. Sustainable productivity means recognising the limitations on our time. Everybody has them."

"If it isn't a 'hell yeah', it's not worth doing. If it isn't a 'hell yeah', it's not worth doing."

"Do less, so that you can unlock more."

*"I'm actually as proud of the things we haven't done as the things I have done."
—Steve Jobs*

"The goal is to spend most of our time focused on just one task—but not beat ourselves up if we occasionally lose concentration."

"Give yourself permission to be distracted."

- Do course correction: If you get distracted, don't beat yourself up or think "Since I already got distracted, I might as well continue." Accept that it's normal to get distracted occasionally, and just return to your main task.



Take regular breaks throughout the day to recharge and maintain your energy/focus. Research found that the most productive workers took a 17-minute break after 52 minutes of job-related tasks.

- Schedule short breaks throughout the day (e.g. 5-10 minutes every hour) to stretch, take a walk, or just do nothing. You can also use techniques like the Pomodoro method to alternate between focused work and regular breaks.
- Not all distractions are bad. Embrace positive distractions that refresh and energize you, such as music or an uplifting conversation.



Recharge



To maintain optimal productivity and avoid depletion burnouts, we must replenish our mind, body and spirit through rest, relaxation, and revitalizing activities.

- You can recharge through creative activities, Nature, or idle relaxation.



Recharge creatively: Engage in CALM, restorative activities that meet 4 criteria: they (i) boost your competence, (ii) give you a sense of autonomy, (iii) offer liberty or freedom from work, and (iv) provide a mellow, relaxing experience.

- Engage in calm hobbies like painting or playing a musical instrument. These are creative, soothing activities that provide enjoyment without requiring productivity. You can improve your skills over time, but the main goal is to enjoy the activity. Don't try to perfect the hobby or make it into work.
- Start calm projects like DIY projects or working on a puzzle. These are creative projects with a clear end-goal. They require gentle focus and offers a sense of accomplishment, but without massive effort or pressure. You can involve other people to make the activities even more rejuvenating.

KEY QUOTES

"As long as we correct course, we'll still end up at our intended destination."

"Find moments in your working day to do nothing. And embrace them."

"Breaks aren't a special treat. They're an absolute necessity."

"Life isn't about maintaining focus all the time. It's about allowing space for little moments of serendipity and joy."

"Your mood is suffering because you haven't given yourself the deeper periods of time off that you need – not just little breaks throughout the day, but the longer breaks that recharge the energy of your mind, body, and spirit."

"Your primary goal is not to become an expert or a master. It's to enjoy and to recharge."

"If you want to properly recharge, you need to maintain areas of your life in which personal advancement doesn't feature at all."



Recharge naturally: Tap into Nature's restorative effects to rejuvenate yourself, reduce stress, and feel better.

- Incorporate nature into your surroundings, e.g. adding plants or nature-inspired artwork to your work area, or opening the windows to let in fresh air. Such natural elements help to improve focus and reduce stress. For instance, patients in a hospital room with tranquil paintings were found to be less anxious and needed less pain medication, compared to those exposed to dark photography, abstract art, or no images at all.
- Go for a walk. Enjoy the gentle physical activity and fresh air, be it a walk through a park or around your office. Ideally, take long walks without a time limit, but even a 10-minute walk could provide a useful mental break.



Recharge mindlessly: Let the mind drift without directed focus, and relax without trying too hard. Neuroscience research shows that when we "do nothing", it triggers the brain's default mode network—it starts to revisit past memories, daydreams, or imagines the future, often leading to creative solutions.

- Let your mind wander freely: Engage in activities that allow the mind to flow freely without specific goals or tasks. Examples include: doodling, staring out of the window, or doing routine chores without listening or watching anything concurrently.
- Embrace the Reitoff Principle: Give yourself permission to just to rest and do nothing at all. Forget about productivity, mindfulness, or engaging in restorative activities. Just write off the entire day or week to rest fully. If you feel guilty taking the break, then remind yourself you'll be more productive when you return from the break feeling fully rested.



Align



Misalignment burnout occurs when we invest time and effort in pursuits that don't match our sense of self, resulting in exhaustion without fulfillment.

- Motivation falls on a spectrum, ranging from external motivation (doing things due to external pressures) to intrinsic motivation (doing things aligned with our interests and

KEY QUOTES

"Nature replenishes our cognitive abilities and boosts our energy."

"If you're looking for a simple and easy way to immediately feel rejuvenated, just try taking a walk—no time limit, no distance to reach, no place in particular to go."

"Doing nothing can be surprisingly productive."

"When the brain relaxes sufficiently, creative solutions do appear."

"Sometimes it's worth doing nothing at all. Not having deep shower thoughts. Not having a gentle walk. Nada."

"By doing less today, you can do more of what matters to you tomorrow."

"Overcoming misalignment is a lifelong task; one that requires us to continually work out what really matters to us, and change our behaviour accordingly."

values). The greater the intrinsic motivation, the more fulfilling and sustainable the activity.

- To sustain productivity, align your goals and actions with your core values and purpose—over the short-term, medium-term, and long-term.



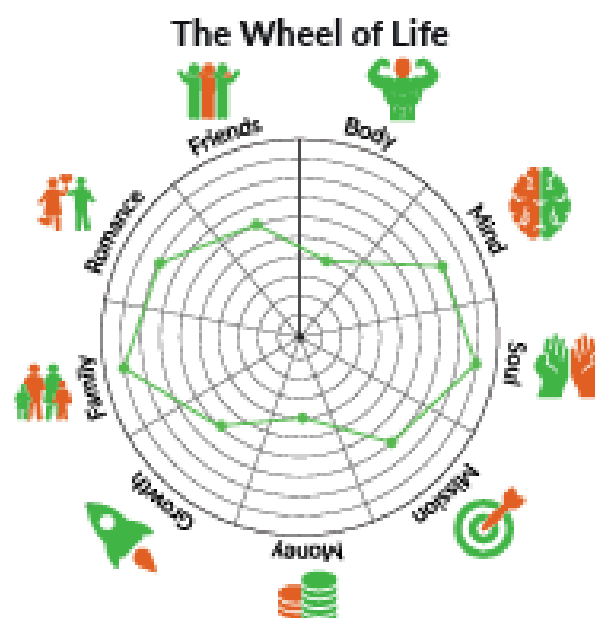
Long-term alignment: Why do people redefine their priorities after life-threatening experiences like a serious accident or illness? Often, they shift their focus away from extrinsic goals (e.g. earning more money) to intrinsic goals (e.g. nurturing close relationships). You don't need a crisis to start focusing on what truly matters to you.

- Write your eulogy: At the end of your life, what would you want your eulogy to be like? What legacy, values, and achievements would you want to leave behind? Use this as a guide to shape your daily actions.
- Map out 3 different life paths for the next 5-10 years, to consider if you're truly on your desired path.
 - (i) *Current path:* What would life be like in 5-10 years if you continued as you are now?
 - (ii) *Alternative path:* What would life look like in 5-10 years if you took a totally different direction?
 - (iii) *Radical path:* What would life look like in 5-10 years if you ignored financial and social expectations?



Medium-term alignment: Align your daily actions with your goals over the next 1 year.

- Use the Wheel of Life chart to assess various aspects of your life.
 - (i) On a scale of 1-10, rate how aligned your actions are with your goals for each area of life, e.g. work, health, relationships.
 - (ii) Create a plan to align the areas that are out of balance.



KEY QUOTES

"We can sustain our feel-good productivity by aligning our present-day actions with a deeper sense of self."

"When we think about death, we get a clearer view of life."

"What does the life you want people to remember in a few decades mean for the life you should build now?"

"By sketching out the paths ahead, you can work out which one you really want to take."

"Values affirmations make our most abstract ideals real. And they boost our confidence along the way. The only question is how to find these values—and how to use them."

KEY QUOTES

- Year-end celebration: Imagine celebrating your progress at the end of 12 months.
 - (i) For each area in your life, what progress or moments would you be the proudest of?
 - (ii) What must you do now to make this celebration a reality?



Short-term alignment: Set up practices to align your day-to-day decisions and actions with your values.

- Daily alignment quests: Choose 3 areas of focus from the Wheel of Life, e.g. relationships, health, and work. Commit to 3 specific actions daily to support your core values. For example:
 - 10am: Send LinkedIn invites to potential mentors (W)
 - 3pm: Call Mom to reconnect (R)
 - 7pm: Swim for 30 minutes (H)
- Alignment experiments: Treat alignment as an ongoing journey. Keep testing ways to align your actions with your values.
 - (i) Identify an area of dissatisfaction, e.g. personal relationships.
 - (ii) Develop a hypothesis: What could you change to improve the situation (e.g. replacing social media time with a walk or chat with a loved one)?
 - (iii) Make the change, assess the impact, and keep fine-tuning.

"With the right tools, we can subtly shift ourselves back towards the things that matter the most."

"The journey to alignment is not one with a clear end-goal. It's a never-ending process."

"As we navigate the laboratory of our lives, we must be willing to embrace experimentation—and to learn as we go."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Feel-Good Productivity is not about doing more; it's about doing what matters in a way that's fulfilling and energizing. The key is to experiment with the strategies and practices above to find out what works best for you. The book includes many other personal anecdotes and empirical research references. For more details, please visit www.feelgoodproductivity.com.

"Don't rote-learn your way to feel-good productivity. Experiment your way."